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RAJ THACKERAY

AMPLIFYING HIS PRESENCE

By Kiran D. Tare

On the face of it, the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray's campaign against the use of loudspeakers in mosques for *azaan* and other purposes met its objective—over 90 per cent did not use them at dawn on May 4, the deadline set by the politician. The silence has persisted since then. As part of his agitation, a combative Raj had also ordered MNS cadre to play the Hanuman Chalisa outside mosques from May 4 if *azaan* was still announced before 6 am (the Supreme Court restricted the use of loudspeakers between 10 pm and 6 am in a 2005 order). It forced the Maharashtra police to implement its 2017 guidelines, which say that use of loudspeakers needed prior permission, with a decibel limit of 55 for religious places. Raj Thackeray's stand is being seen as a muscular and daring move to seize the political initiative that the MNS was thought to have irretrievably lost after a string of poor electoral results. Through this successful sally, Raj has regained some space in state politics ahead of crucial local body elections later this year. Moreover, with his eager use of Hindutva, he has pushed estranged cousin and Chief Minister Uddhav Thackeray into a corner.

One sign came in 2020, when Raj replaced the multi-coloured MNS flag with a saffron one. With the Shiv Sena allied with the secular Congress and the Nationalist Congress party (NCP) in the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA), Raj was waiting for an issue that would leave Uddhav with little room for manoeuvre. The issue of mosque loudspeakers was cleverly chosen—the Sena could not oppose the move without being accused of 'Muslim appeasement'.

IN CHOOSING THE CHALISA, RAJ IS SEEKING TO WOO NORTH INDIANS. A VISIT TO AYODHYA IS THE NEXT STEP

Several of the MVA government's decisions have fuelled an impression that the Sena no longer has 'Hindu interests' in mind. It delayed the reopening of temples after Covid restrictions were lifted last year. The government's decision to give scholarships to poor Muslim students was also painted as 'appeasement' by the BJP.

Moreover, Raj correctly judged the mood of Sena workers unhappy with Uddhav's role in a secular front. Now, it seems he has succeeded in weaning away some Sena supporters, especially in Marathi-dominated areas of central Mumbai. "I voted for Sena even when it separated from the BJP because I liked its aggression," says Gautam Narvekar, a resident of Kurla. "As Raj has taken a more aggressive stand than Uddhav, I will now think whether to vote for Sena again," says Narvekar, a 35-year-old employee with a private company.

Raj did desperately need a straw or two to clutch to—consecutive assembly elections in 2014 and 2019 were disastrous for the MNS. It could win only one seat in each (with a vote share of 3.15 and a dispiriting 0.35, respectively) after an impressive show (13 seats, with a vote share of 5.71) in 2009. Following a similar trend, the MNS's strength in the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) came down to one in 2017 from 27 in 2012. The loudspeaker issue has helped him wriggle out of an existential crisis. "We must win at least five seats in